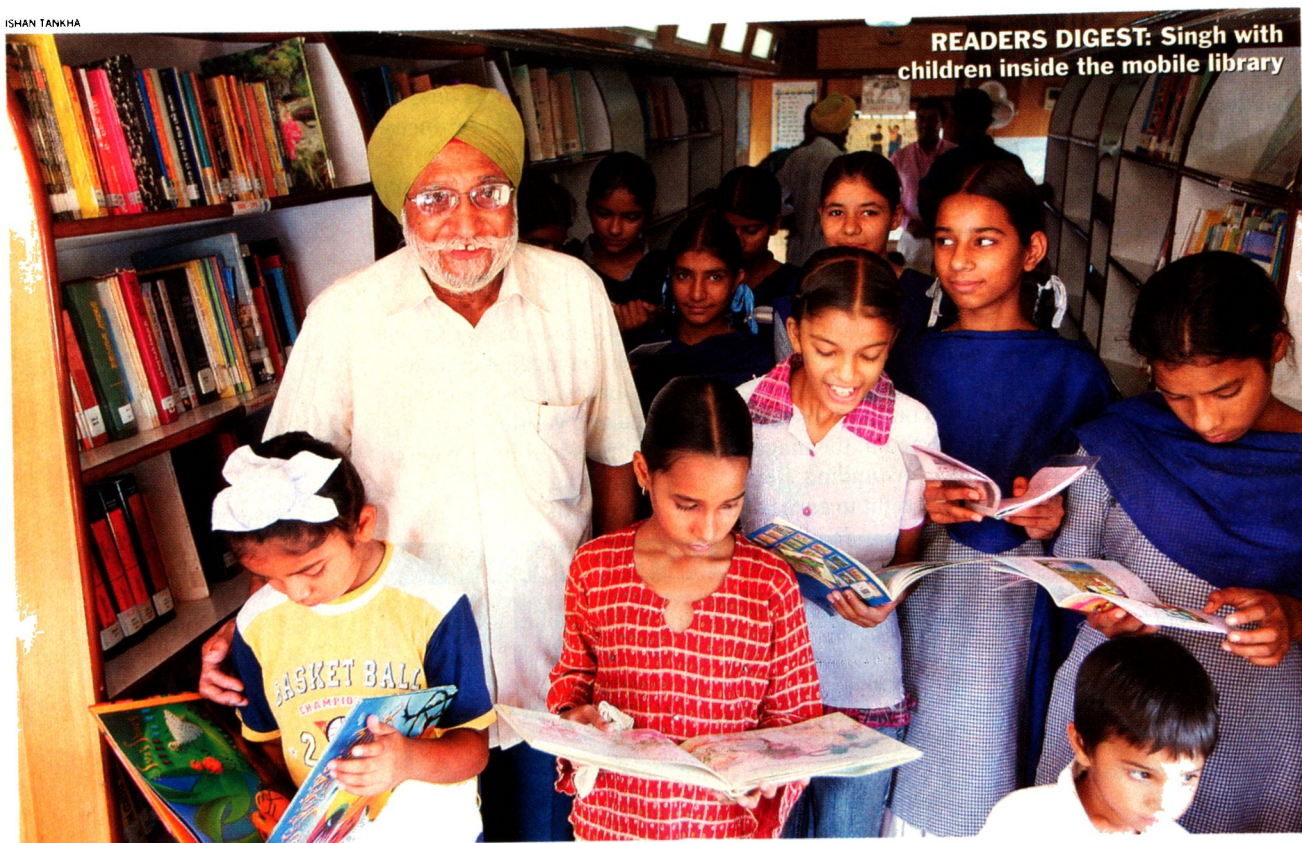


ISHAN TANKHA



Words on Wheels

A mobile library has become a new source of enlightenment for 15,000 readers in six villages

■ **By Ramesh Vinayak**

It's a sweltering afternoon in Gujarwal, a village in the interiors of Punjab's Ludhiana district. But the languid village square springs to life as a caravan-like bus rolls in and is parked in front of the Government Girls' High School. Both elders and children board the air-conditioned vehicle and are instantly transported to a world of knowledge. For it is a library on wheels—the first of its kind in the state—run by Jaswant Singh, a US citizen. Singh makes two or three long trips to India every year and has hired two persons to manage the library.

The bus has on its racks 3,000-odd books on a wide range of subjects. There are children's books, those on general knowledge and even some out-of-print books by eminent Punjabi writers. The library reaches out to 15,000 people in six villages—Jorahan, Gujarwal, Rangoowal, Phallewal, Kalakh and Dhulkot—twice a week. Singh, 73, adds 300 new books every year. A Ph.D in library science from the Western Michigan University and librarian in American schools for three decades, he invested Rs 30-lakh into the venture modelled on the American bookmobile concept. "In a democratic society, every child has the right to have access to knowledge without a direct cost," says Singh who provides



the locals books free of cost.

The mobile library's popularity is reflected in the growing number of the books issued to the locals—from 508 in 2004 to 6,354 last year. "The bookmobile has promoted the reading culture among the young generation," says Gujarwal *sarpanch* Lakhwinder Singh.

Singh started this initiative in his native village, Jorahan, in 2003 with the aim of reviving the book culture in rural areas. He wanted to set up an example in public library service to drive home his campaign to push the state government into enacting the Public Library Act. "Without the Act, Punjab will fail to benefit from the Knowledge Commission report which recognises a public library as an extremely important element of knowledge economy," he says.

The Act provides for the establishment, operation and maintenance of an integrated, comprehensive and efficient rural and urban public library system. In India, only 12 states have enacted the Act so far. Not surprisingly, Punjab has only 17 public libraries compared to 35,000 in West Bengal. The Act will not only lead to a proliferation of libraries, but will also help stem the school dropout rate and create at least 40,000 jobs. "I am not going to die before seeing this Act through in Punjab," says Singh passionately. ■